

INTRODUCTION TO FILM ANALYSIS



Joan Fontaine and Louis Jourdan in 'Letter from an Unknown Woman' (Max Ophüls, 1948)

Description

This course is designed to equip students with the tools necessary to become critically aware and capable film viewers by introducing elements of film form, processes of textual analysis, a variety of cinematic techniques used in narrative and non-narrative cinema, and other models of critical analysis used in film criticism.

Outcomes

After completing the course, students should have acquired the following skills:

- Ability to analyze technical/formal components of film narratives (shot composition, cinematography, editing, use of color, sound, narrative structure, genre, or style) as a path to understanding their intended meanings
- Basic understanding of major interpretative frameworks by which film narratives can be analyzed and ability to apply one or more of these frameworks to the analysis of specific film narratives
- Understanding of methodological and stylistic differences between forms of writing about film, including movie reviews, critical essays, theoretical essays, fan discourse
- Ability to deploy the above analytical skills in critical essays that analyze the meaning of films as cultural texts

FILM 270-01-SP26

4 credits

[Keene State College](#)

Department of Film

Spring Semester 2026

Monday 10:00 a.m.-1:30 p.m.

Parker Hall: Drenan Auditorium

Instructor: Dr. Martin Roberts

Office hours: Monday 16:00-17:00

Office location: Media Arts 124

[Canvas](#)

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Reading Assignments

The following texts are required for the course. Please order them as soon as possible.

Ed Sikov, *Film Studies: An Introduction*. Second edition. New York: Columbia University Press, 2020.

Other reading assignments will be available in PDF format via links in the syllabus. Please download all PDFs (see also Files page for all PDFs), print them out and mark them up when reading.

Writing Assignments

Screening Reports (45%)

3 short analyses of films (500-750 words / 2-3 pages)

Genre Case Study (15%)

1,000 words / 4 pages

Critical Essay (25%)

Analysis of 1 or more films by one director, or belonging to a particular genre. Due exam week. Letter grade. 1,500-1,750 words (with bibliography, not included in word count) / 6-7 pages

Engagement (15%)

Includes attendance, punctuality, participation in in-class and online discussions, individual conferences regarding course materials, etc.

Sources: Video Essay

[kogonada](#)

[Mubi Video Essays](#) (YouTube playlist)

[Observations on Film Art](#) (Criterion channel)

Sources: Other

[A Sharper Focus: Essays on Film by Norman Holland](#)

[Criterion](#)

[Justwatch](#)

[Letterboxd](#)

[Metrograph](#)

[Mubi](#)

[The Language of Film](#) (interactive infographic on film-analysis concepts; for the iOS/Android app, search "Close-Up Film Language" on the App Store)

[Movie Database](#)

Schedule of classes

Week 1 (Mon 01/19)

NO CLASS (Martin Luther King Day)

Week 2 (Mon 01/26)

NO CLASS (Snow day)

Week 3 (Mon 02/02)

Watch:

FILM (Tacita Dean, 2011)

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lefVPUYGvi0>

The Definition of Film (Richard Misek, 2015)

Sikov, *Film Studies: An Introduction*: "**Mise-en-Scène: Within the Image**" (ch. 1) [same pdf]

Screening: *Le Rayon Vert* [*The Green Ray*] (Éric Rohmer, 1986)

Week 4 (Mon 02/09)

Trains of Thought: The Cinematic Experience

Francesco Casetti, "**The Relocation of Cinema**" in Shane Denson and Julia Leyda, eds., *Post-Cinema: Theorizing 21st-Century Film* (Sussex: REFRAME Books, 2015). Read at least the first two sections, preferably all.

Wolfgang Schivelbusch, "**Panoramic Travel**," in *The Railway Journey: Trains and Travel in the Nineteenth Century* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1980)

Allison C. Meier, "**Cycloramas: The Virtual Reality of the 19th Century**[Links to an external site.](#)" (JSTOR Daily, 16 December 2018)

Charles Dennis, "**Letter from an Unknown Woman**" (*Criterion Channel*, 25 May 1992)

Rebecca Mead, "**The Scourge of 'Relatability'**" (*New Yorker*, 1 August 2014)

Screening: *Letter from an Unknown Woman* (Max Ophüls, 1948)

Week 5 (Mon 02/16)

Spectral Cinema

"Spectral Cinema: Retratos Fantasma"

Screening: *Retratos Fantasma* (Kleber Mendonça Filho, 2023)

Week 6 (Mon 02/23)

NO CLASS (Snow day)

Deadline: First Screening Report

Week 7 (Mon 03/02)

Building Blocks: Shot, Scene, Sequence

Sikov, "Mise-en-Scène: Camera Movement" (*Film Studies: An Introduction*, ch. 2)

Screenings:

- "[*The Shining* and the Steadicam®: an interview with inventor Garrett Brown"

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YpcP-6nBi5c&t=5s>

- *Personal Shopper* (Olivier Assayas, 2016)
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Week 8 (Mon 03/09)

Framing Reality: Lighting, Focus, Aspect Ratio

Sikov, *Film Studies*: "Cinematography" (ch. 3)

Screening: *A Ghost Story* (David Lowery, 2017)

SPRING BREAK

Week 9 (Mon 03/23)

Writing about film

[Kogonada video essays](#) (Bresson, Hitchcock)

[Film Grab](#) (frame datasets)

[Film Studies Resources](#)

Week 10 (Mon 03/30)

Auteurs and Art Cinema

Sikov, "Filmmakers" (*Film Studies*, ch. 8)

Bordwell, "The Art Cinema as a Mode of Film Practice"

Vincendeau, "Sixty Years of the French New Wave, From Hysteria to Nostalgia and Beyond" (in Peter Graham and Ginette Vincendeau, eds., *The French New Wave: Critical Landmarks* (London: BFI, 2009))

Flitterman-Lewis, "Another Gaze" (on Agnès Varda)

Deadline: Second Screening Report

Week 11 (Mon 04/06)

Genre

Sikov, "Genre" (*Film Studies*, ch. 10)

Altman, "A Semantic/Syntactic Approach to Film Genre"

Vincendeau, "How the French Birthed Film Noir"

Week 12 (Mon 04/13)

Ideology Sikov, "Film and Ideology" (*Film Studies*, ch. 12)

Week 13 (Mon 04/22)

Digital Cinema

Sikov, "Digital Cinema" (*Film Studies*, ch. 13)

Manovich, "What Is Digital Cinema?" (1995)

Prince, "True Lies: Perceptual Realism, Digital Images, and Film Theory"

For video clips screened in class, see [Video Library](#):

- *San Francisco, A Trip down Market Street, 14 April 1906* (AI upscale by Denis Shiryayev)
- *Cyberpunk 2077 - Night Walk in Kabuki* (walkthrough)
- *Dawson City: Frozen Time* (trailer) (Bill Morrison, 2016)
- *Gravity | Making Of... Featurette* (2013)

Screenings:

- *Dr. Strange* (Scott Derrickson, 2016)
 - *Gravity* (Alfonso Cuarón, 2013)
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Week 14 (Mon 04/27)

Return to Realism

Bazin, "The Ontology of the Photographic Image" (*What Is Cinema?* (1967). (First published: 1945)

05/01 Last day of classes

Reading Day (Mon 05/04)

Exam period (Tues-Fri 05/05-08)

DEADLINE: Tuesday 05/05 Critical Essay

Readings & assignments

Readings assigned for each week should be completed **prior to** the class meeting. Assignments are due at the beginning of the class unless stated otherwise. **Do not email submissions.**

Discussion & participation

Class discussion (i.e. your participation) is one of the most essential parts of this class. Please come to class fully prepared. Also keep in mind that we always need to work together in order to create a productive and inspiring academic environment by being polite and respectful toward other students' comments and ideas. In order to ensure full participation and engagement in class, the use of laptops and/or mobile devices during lectures, discussion, and screenings is not permitted.

Academic honesty

We understand and agree that we are participating in higher education. We respect this process and will act as mature and responsible individuals in it. To ensure that, all students are expected to hand in original written work. Using other people's words without proper attribution constitutes plagiarism. Plagiarism and any other forms of cheating will result in an F for the assignment and may include further College sanctions. In this class, every student must be aware of and adhere to the college's policy on academic honesty. Detailed procedures and processes pertaining to the Policy on Academic Honesty can be viewed at <http://www.keene.edu/policy/academichonesty.cfm>